

How to give a golden touch to the silver years

Old age **often conjures** images of **frailty**, dependence and **withdrawal**. But it can be a second **bloom**—a chance to **embrace** life with renewed **vigour**

John and Hazel are a couple in their eighties. They were our neighbours at a mountain resort in Germany and were on a two-week holiday. They had come from the UK, driving nonstop for hours. They went hiking in **the woods**, drove to nearby places of interest even on snowy and rainy days without **cursing** the weather, made their own breakfast in their room instead of **indulging in** the buffet, and seemed to be having the best of their times.

When I spoke to them, I saw how **enthused** they were about their retired lives, **looking forward** to travelling more, seeing more places on earth, and not once did they mention any discomfort that might be commonplace at their age: creaking knees, **waning** memory, **shivering** hands, **feeble** limbs.

This is the kind of old age I wish for myself and my spouse. Though, truth be told, 'wish' feels more honest than '**envisage**' because I am unsure if I will see the world that far ahead. Pushing my mid-fifties, I am already troubled by the thought of a **frail** old age where my body might fail me, denying me the chance to **drink life to the lees**. Health issues have started giving me early warnings. And every time I travel to the West and see people older than me by a few **decades** living with independence, engagement, and joy, I am **overcome** not with **envy** but with **wonder**-and a quiet **determination**.

Why do we, in India, not **envision** such a golden old age for ourselves? Why do we resign ourselves so early to physical decline, social withdrawal, and the weight of **ailments**? Somewhere along the way, we have been conditioned to expect aging as a slow **retreat** from life rather than an opportunity for a second bloom. Part of it **lies** in our cultural mindset, perhaps-where old age is often **equated** with **quietude**, dependence, and spiritual **pursuits**.

In contrast, many Western cultures emphasise personal fulfillment and activity well into the later years of life. Retirees continue to travel, explore hobbies, and stay physically active, seeing old age as a continuation of life rather than its decline. We Indians often embrace a more **sedentary** old age, **citing** health issues, familial **obligations**, or even spirituality as reasons to **wind down**. But does spirituality have to mean withdrawal?

The **narrative** around aging **needs** to shift-from **enduring** to embracing, from retiring to **thriving**. Perhaps, if we break free from the cultural **mould** of **passive** aging and **take cues** from people like John and Hazel, we can look forward to a life where the **sunset years** are not just endured but truly, deeply lived.

To achieve this, we must adopt a **proactive** approach. Regular physical activity **tailored to** our abilities can significantly enhance **mobility** and reduce age-related health issues. **Prioritising** balanced nutrition with a focus on protein intake and essential vitamins **is** key to maintaining strength and

mental clarity. Beyond physical wellness, **fostering** emotional well-being by staying connected with friends, family, and community can **counter isolation** and **loneliness**, which often **accompany** aging.

Moreover, financial planning cannot be **overlooked**. A secure financial base can **empower** older adults to **pursue passions**, travel, and stay engaged in life. Ultimately, aging is a privilege-a phase of life that can be as **vibrant** and fulfilling as any other if approached with the right mindset.

Let us not **merely aspire for** longer lives but richer ones, where we continue to explore, learn, and inspire generations that follow. The golden years can truly be golden if we choose to make them so. To John, Hazel and dozens others that I **come across** on my **jaunts** to the other side of the **globe**, thank you. For making me see life in a whole new **perspective**. **[Practice Exercise]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **A golden touch** (phrase) – An ability to be successful at anything endeavored.
2. **Silver years** (noun) – Older age, senior years, twilight years, retirement phase वृद्धावस्था
3. **Often** (adverb) – Frequently, regularly, repeatedly, commonly अक्सर
4. **Conjure** (verb) – Evoke, bring to mind, summon, call forth उत्पन्न करना
5. **Frailty** (noun) – Weakness, delicacy, fragility, feebleness कमजोरी
6. **Withdrawal** (noun) – Retreat, pulling back, isolation, disengagement अलगाव
7. **Bloom** (noun) – Flowering, flourishing, blossom, prime खिलना
8. **Embrace** (verb) – Accept, welcome, adopt, take on अपनाना
9. **Vigour** (noun) – Energy, enthusiasm, vitality, dynamism जोश/ऊर्जा
10. **The woods** (noun) – Forested area, woodland, forest, timberland जंगल
11. **Curse** (verb) – Complain bitterly about, denounce, revile, swear at कोसना
12. **Indulge** (in) (verb) – Treat oneself to, partake of, allow oneself, give in to आनंद लेना
13. **Enthuse** (verb) – Excite, inspire, fill with eagerness, animate उत्साहित करना
14. **Look forward to** (phrase) – Anticipate, expect, await eagerly, be excited about उत्सुकता से प्रतीक्षा करना
15. **Waning** (adjective) – Diminishing, decreasing, weakening, declining घटती हुई
16. **Shivering** (adjective) – Trembling, quivering, shaking, shuddering काँपता हुआ
17. **Feeble** (adjective) – Weak, frail, delicate, powerless कमजोर
18. **Envisage** (verb) – Imagine, envision, foresee, conceive कल्पना करना
19. **Frail** (adjective) – Delicate, feeble, weak, infirm कमजोर
20. **Drink life to the lees** (phrase) – Live life fully, seize life's opportunities, make the most of life जीवन का पूरा आनंद लेना
21. **Decade** (noun) – Period of ten years दशक
22. **Overcome** (verb) – Conquer, surmount, prevail over, triumph over पार पाना
23. **Envy** (noun) – Jealousy, covetousness, resentment, desire ईर्ष्या
24. **Wonder** (noun) – Awe, amazement, astonishment, admiration आश्चर्य
25. **Determination** (noun) – Resolve, firmness of purpose, tenacity, perseverance संकल्प

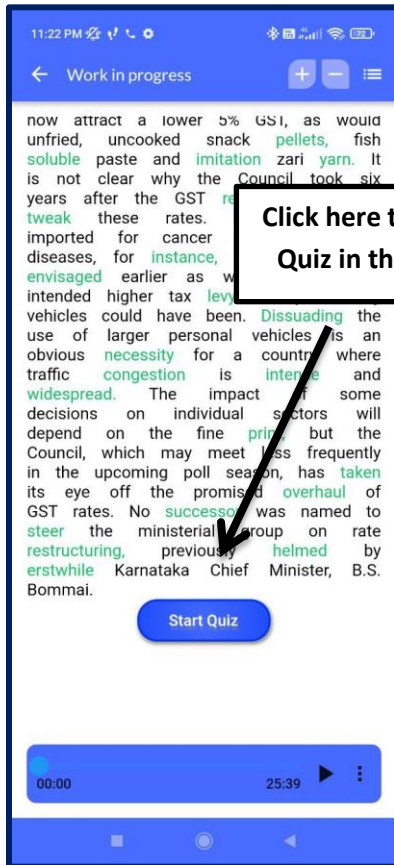
26. **Envision** (verb) – Picture, visualize, conceive, see in the mind's eye कल्पना करना
27. **Ailment** (noun) – Illness, disease, malady, affliction बीमारी
28. **Retreat** (noun) – Withdrawal, pullback, retirement, secluded place अलगाव/वापसी
29. **Lies** (in) (verb) – Resides in, consists in, is found in, depends on में रहना
30. **Equate** (verb) – Compare, consider equal, associate, liken समान मानना
31. **Quietude** (noun) – Calmness, silence, stillness, tranquility शांति
32. **Pursuit** (noun) – Activity, hobby, goal, quest गतिविधि/उद्देश्य
33. **In contrast** (phrase) – On the other hand, by comparison, conversely इसके विपरीत
34. **Sedentary** (adjective) – Inactive, desk-bound, stationary, sitting-based गतिहीन
35. **Cite** (verb) – Refer to, mention, quote, bring up हवाला देना
36. **Obligation** (noun) – Duty, responsibility, requirement, commitment कर्तव्य
37. **Wind down** (phrasal verb) – Relax, slow down, ease off, reduce activity धीमा होना/शांति लेना
38. **Narrative** (noun) – Story, account, perspective, viewpoint कथा/वृत्तांत
39. **Endure** (verb) – Persist, withstand, bear, survive सहन करना
40. **Thrive** (verb) – Prosper, flourish, bloom, succeed फलना-फूलना
41. **Mould** (noun) – Form, shape, pattern, framework साँचा
42. **Passive** (adjective) – Inactive, submissive, unresisting, compliant निष्क्रिय
43. **Take cue** (phrase) – Follow example, be inspired, take direction, learn from संकेत लेना
44. **Sunset year** (noun) – Later stage in life, twilight years, senior years, final phase वृद्धावस्था
45. **Proactive** (adjective) – Taking initiative, anticipatory, forward-looking, taking charge अग्रसक्रिय
46. **Tailor** (verb) – Adapt, customize, fit, modify अनुकूलित करना
47. **Mobility** (noun) – Ability to move, freedom of movement, flexibility, agility गतिशीलता
48. **Foster** (verb) – Encourage, promote, nurture, cultivate बढ़ावा देना
49. **Counter** (verb) – Offset, oppose, respond to, negate मुकाबला करना
50. **Isolation** (noun) – Loneliness, solitude, separation, seclusion अलगाव

51. **Loneliness** (noun) – Solitude, aloneness, desolation, emptiness अकेलापन
52. **Accompany** (verb) – Go along with, occur alongside, come with, be present with साथ होना
53. **Moreover** (adverb) – Furthermore, in addition, besides, also इसके अलावा
54. **Overlooked** (adjective) – Neglected, disregarded, ignored, passed over उपेक्षित
55. **Empower** (verb) – Enable, authorize, equip, give power अधिकार देना
56. **Pursue** (verb) – Follow, strive for, chase after, go after पीछा करना/लक्ष्य रखना
57. **Passion** (noun) – Enthusiasm, zeal, fervor, strong interest जुनून
58. **Vibrant** (adjective) – Energetic, lively, dynamic, spirited जीवंत
59. **Merely** (adverb) – Only, just, simply, no more than मात्र
60. **Aspire** (verb) – Yearn for, aim for, strive after, desire आकांक्षा रखना
61. **Come across** (phrasal verb) – Encounter, meet unexpectedly, run into, discover आमना-सामना होना
62. **Jaunt** (noun) – Short trip, excursion, outing, journey छोटी यात्रा
63. **Globe** (noun) – World, Earth, planet, global community संसार/पृथ्वी
64. **Perspective** (noun) – Viewpoint, outlook, standpoint, angle दृष्टिकोण

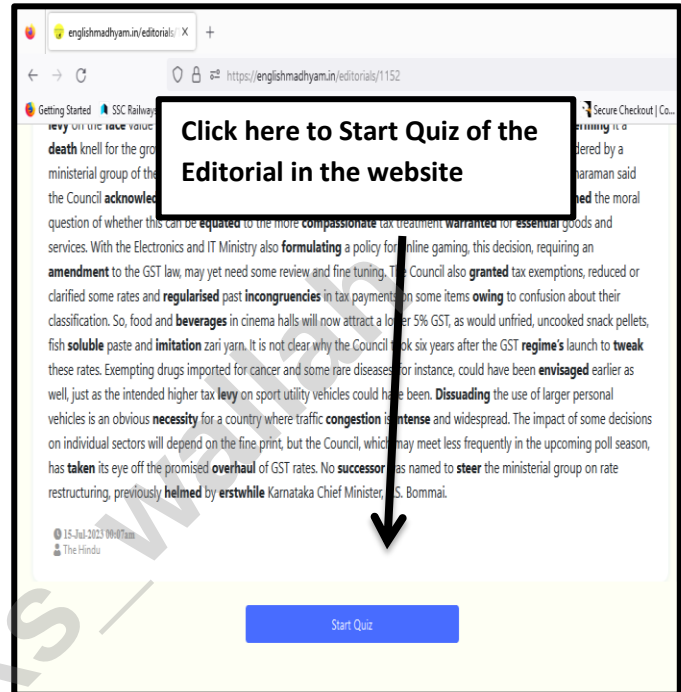
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Old Age Stereotypes:** Aging is often associated with frailty, dependence, and withdrawal, but it can be a vibrant, fulfilling phase of life.
2. **John and Hazel's Story:** The writer narrates the inspiring example of an elderly couple enjoying an active and adventurous life, defying stereotypes of aging.
3. **Personal Reflection:** The writer expresses admiration and a desire for a similar golden old age, contrasting it with fears of frailty and physical decline.
4. **Cultural Conditioning in India:** In India, old age is viewed as a retreat from life, shaped by cultural expectations of dependence and spiritual pursuits.
5. **Western Contrast:** Western cultures often emphasize personal fulfillment, independence, and activity into old age, seeing it as a continuation rather than a decline.
6. **Shifting Narratives:** The perception of aging needs to change from enduring life to embracing it, and from passive retirement to active thriving.
7. **Learning from Others:** Taking inspiration from active seniors like John and Hazel can help envision a more vibrant old age.
8. **Physical Activity:** Regular exercise tailored to abilities enhances mobility, reduces health issues, and promotes independence in older adults.
9. **Balanced Nutrition:** Proper diet, rich in proteins and essential nutrients, is vital for maintaining strength, energy, and mental clarity.
10. **Emotional Well-being:** Staying connected with loved ones and communities can counter loneliness and foster happiness in later years.
11. **Financial Planning:** A secure financial foundation is crucial to pursuing hobbies, travel, and engagement in life during old age.
12. **Proactive Approach:** A conscious effort to maintain physical, emotional, and financial health can transform aging into an enriching experience.
13. **Aging as a Privilege:** Growing older should be viewed as an opportunity to learn, explore, and inspire rather than as a burden or limitation.
14. **Rejecting Passivity:** Spirituality and reflection in old age need not equate to withdrawal or inactivity.
15. **A New Perspective:** By reimagining the later years as a golden phase of life, one can aspire for not just longer lives but richer, more fulfilling ones.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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